argument.… So that was my first reading of the EPR paper, and I didn't think anything was wrong with the argument. It seemed to be a very good argument. I never saw anything wrong with it."

Shimony quickly found himself overwhelmed by the density of the mathematics that Wightman was working with and decided to switch to a different area of physics. "I… turned to Wigner for a problem in statistical mechanics," Shimony recalled. "One of the great side-effects of studying with Wigner was that I learned about his ideas on the foundations of quantum mechanics, especially on the measurement problem.… He took a stand contrary to the orthodoxy of the time that the measurement problem had not been solved by the Copenhagen Interpretation." Despite the fact that Shimony's thesis wasn't related to the interpretation of quantum physics, Shimony became Wigner's informal philosophy consultant for Wigner's papers on the measurement problem. The two men shared similar beliefs on the subject, to a point. "I already was inclined to doubt the Copenhagen solution," Shimony wrote, "because it was cognate to some of the positivist epistemological arguments of Mach, Russell, Carnap, Ayer, etc., which I had earlier studied and rejected.… I had long adhered to a version of realism."

But Shimony split with Wigner on the solution to the measurement problem. Shortly after completing his physics PhD in 1962, Shimony wrote a paper on the measurement problem, affirming that the problem was real—and rejecting the idea that consciousness could provide a solution. "There is no empirical evidence that the mind is endowed with the power… of reducing superpositions," Shimony wrote, "and furthermore, there is no obvious way of explaining the agreement among different observers who independently observe physical systems." (Shimony had never been one to shy away from disagreeing with his teachers or from voicing unpopular opinions: when he was in high school in Memphis in the 1940s, he caused trouble with his spirited defense of evolutionary theory in the classroom.) But Wigner, true to form, didn't mind Shimony's dissent—indeed, he had encouraged Shimony to write the paper. Shimony, in turn, needed the encouragement in the face of the vast indifference of most physicists to such work at the time: "It certainly was important for morale to have Wigner's endorsement of the importance of research in foundations of quantum mechanics."